

When Anger Speaks

Understand the Message Behind Your Emotions

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Anger Is Not the Enemy

Anger is one of the most misunderstood human emotions. Many people learn that anger is bad, dangerous, or something they should avoid. But anger itself is not the problem. **Anger is information.** It may signal that something important needs attention: a need, a value, a boundary, or a sense of safety.

The goal is not to eliminate anger. The goal is to understand its message and respond in a way that creates the outcome we want.

Emotions Are Like Dashboard Gauges

When a warning light appears on a vehicle's dashboard, the light is not the enemy—it is information. We do not remove the light because we dislike what it tells us. We ask, "What needs my attention?"

Emotions can provide information about our needs, values, relationships, safety, and beliefs. The goal is not to turn off the gauges. It is to learn how to read them.

What Feelings May Be Telling Us

Fear may signal threat, uncertainty, or a need for safety and preparation. It asks: *What would help me feel safer or more prepared?*

Sadness may signal that something meaningful has been lost or changed. It asks: *What mattered to me that I need to acknowledge and process?*

Loneliness may signal a need for meaningful connection, understanding, or belonging. It asks: *Where do I need deeper connection?*

Boredom may signal a need for engagement, challenge, creativity, or purpose. It asks: *What meaningful activity or challenge is missing?*

Guilt may signal that our actions do not match our values. It can guide responsibility, repair, apology, and learning. It asks: *Is there something I need to acknowledge or change?*

Shame says, "There is something wrong with me," while guilt says, "I did something wrong." Shame attacks identity and worth. It asks: *What belief about myself is creating this pain?*

Frustration often comes from feeling blocked or unable to make progress. It asks: *What adjustment might help me move forward?*

Anger and Reaction Are Different

Anger is the emotion. A reaction is what we do with the energy of that emotion.

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For example, when someone cuts you off in traffic, anger may communicate: “That was dangerous.” We can react by trying to get even—or we can recognize, “That scared me. I need to slow down and stay safe.”

Same event. Same emotion. Different response.

Anger provides energy. Wisdom helps determine how to use it.

Why We React Before We Think

Emotions happen quickly because the brain is designed to protect us. When it senses a threat, it can activate fight, flight, or freeze. These systems are useful in danger, but they can also activate during criticism, conflict, feeling ignored, disrespected, or rejected.

In intense moments, the protective parts of the brain can become more active while thoughtful problem-solving becomes harder to access. This is why people sometimes say, “I wasn’t thinking.” The goal is not to eliminate emotion. The goal is to create enough space for choice.

Why Some Anger Feels Bigger Than Other Anger

A present situation may connect with older experiences of criticism, rejection, feeling unsafe, ignored, unimportant, or powerless. When that happens, today’s event can activate an older emotional pattern.

Imagine a piano and guitar tuned to the same note. When the piano plays, the guitar may begin to vibrate. In the same way, a current event can resonate with an unresolved experience from the past. Recognizing this does not invalidate today’s feelings. It helps explain their intensity and gives us another place to begin healing.

Creating the Pause

The skill that changes everything is learning to create a pause between **feeling** and **reaction**.

Mindfulness is not about emptying the mind. It is learning to notice thoughts, observe feelings, recognize physical sensations, and choose a response.

Instead of saying, “I am angry,” try: **“I am noticing anger.”** That small shift creates space—and space creates choice.

Meditation can help train this skill. Each time the mind wanders and we gently bring it back, we practice awareness. Over time, we become better at noticing what is happening before automatically acting on it. The goal is not perfection. The goal is practice.

A Practical Reflection

Think about a recent situation in which you felt angry. Write or discuss only what feels safe.

1. **What happened?** Describe the event without judgment.

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2. **What did I believe it meant?** What meaning did your mind assign to it?
3. **What emotion may have been underneath the anger?** Fear, hurt, sadness, disrespect, rejection, or feeling unimportant?
4. **What response would create the outcome I actually want?**
5. **What would help me create a pause next time?**

Group Reflection

You may pass at any time. Listen to understand rather than to fix, compare, or judge.

- What messages about anger did you learn growing up?
- What might anger be trying to tell you?
- How can you recognize the difference between anger and reaction?
- What helps you create space during an intense moment?
- What response would better support the outcome you want?

Closing Thought

Anger is not your enemy. It is information. When you understand the message, recognize old patterns, and create a pause between feeling and reaction, you gain more freedom.

Emotion is information. Reaction is a choice. The pause creates freedom.

About the Author

Adam Fistler is a Behavioral Change Consultant, Board Certified Hypnotist, Certified 5-PATH® Hypnotist, and former owner of the Baltimore Hypnosis Center. A member of the International 5-PATH® Hypnosis Association and certified by the National Guild of Hypnotists, Adam has studied hypnosis, behavior change, and the relationship between thoughts, beliefs, emotions, and behavior for more than two decades.

His perspective is shaped by both professional training and personal experience. Adam has lived through addiction and recovery, giving him an understanding of the struggle from both sides: as a practitioner who has helped others create change and as someone who has confronted deeply ingrained patterns and beliefs in his own life.

Today, Adam combines professional knowledge with lessons from his own journey to help people explore meaningful change. His approach is grounded in empathy, curiosity, practical tools, and the belief that people are more than the behaviors they are trying to overcome.